



Surveys and
Observations:
Describing What
People Do

Roadmap

According to the Textbook

- Construct validity of surveys and polls
- Construct validity of behavioral observations

Fun

- Subverting the Measurement

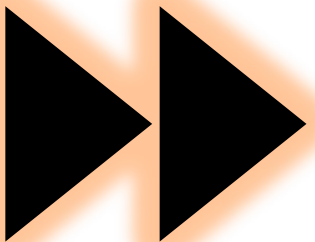
Construct Validity of Surveys and Polls

Survey/poll

Choosing question formats

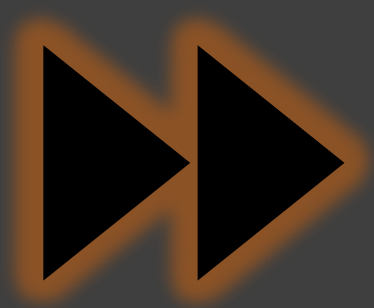
Writing well-worded questions

Encouraging accurate responses



Choosing Question Formats

- Likert scale
 - How difficult is this class?
 - Easy 1 2 3 4 5 Hard
 - Semantic differential format
-
- Open-ended questions
 - What do you think of this class?
 - Forced-choice format
 - Do you like this class so far?
 - Yes or No



Writing Well-Worded Questions

WHEN THE QUESTION WAS WORDED LIKE THIS:

DELAWARE VOTERS' SUPPORT FOR VOTER ID LAWS WAS:

What is your opinion? Do you strongly favor, mostly favor, mostly oppose, or strongly oppose voter ID laws?

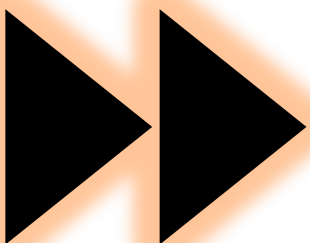
79%

Opponents of voter ID laws argue that they will prevent people who are eligible to vote from voting. What is your opinion? Do you strongly favor, mostly favor, mostly oppose, or strongly oppose voter ID laws?

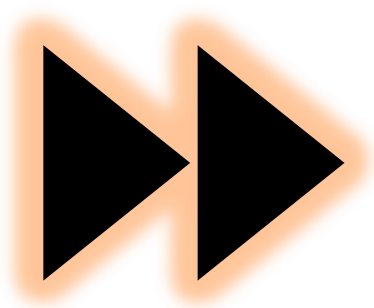
69%

Opponents of voter ID laws argue that they will prevent people who are eligible to vote from voting, and that the laws will affect African American voters especially hard. What is your opinion? Do you strongly favor, mostly favor, mostly oppose, or strongly oppose voter ID laws?

61%



Writing Well-Worded Questions



Double-barreled question

- Do you enjoy swimming and wearing sunscreen?

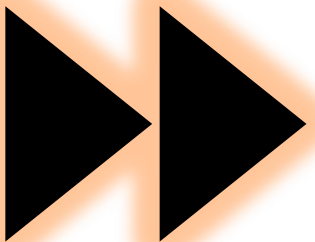
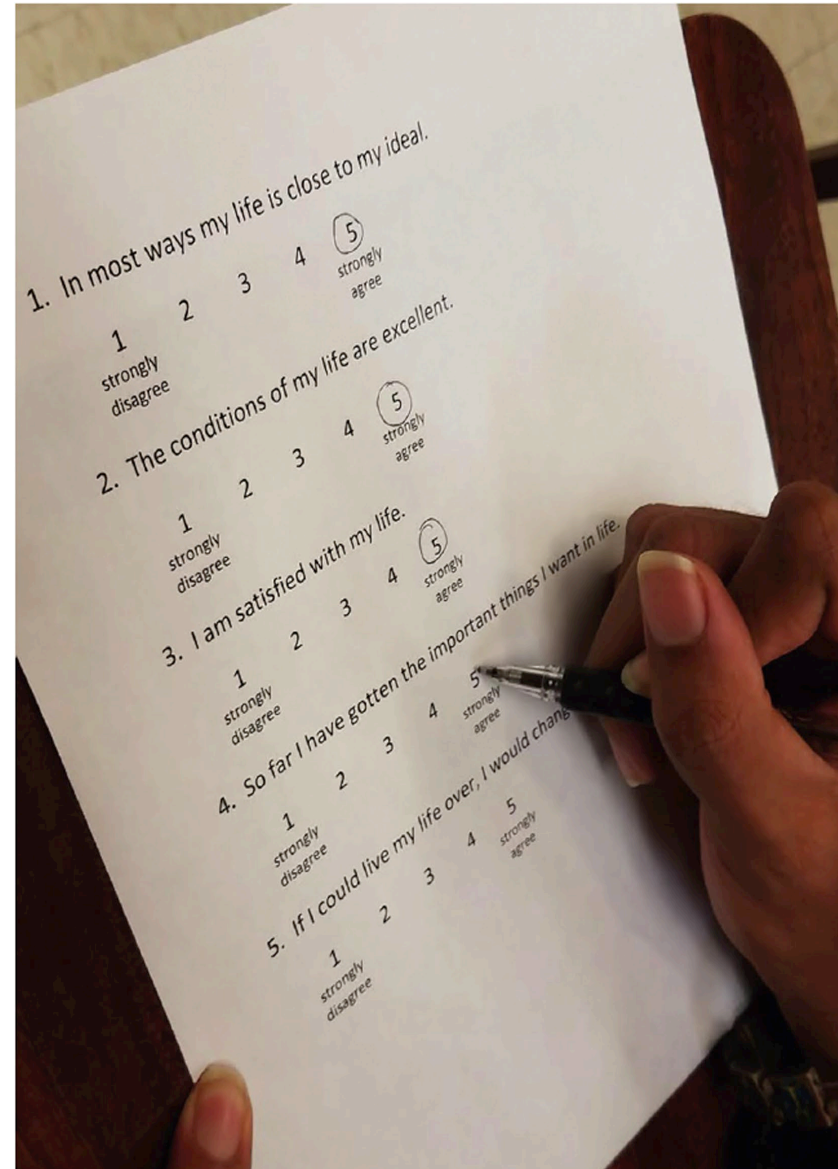
Negatively worded question

- People who do not drive with a suspended license should never be punished.
- Disagree 1 2 3 4 5 Agree

Question order

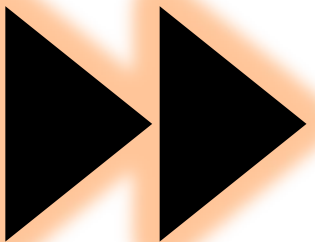
Encouraging Accurate Responses

- People can give meaningful responses
- Sometimes people use shortcuts
 - **Response sets**
 - **Acquiescence** (yea-saying)
 - **Fence sitting**



Encouraging Accurate Responses

- Trying to look good
 - **Socially desirable responding/faking good**
 - **Faking bad**
- Self-reporting “more than they can know”
- Self-reporting memories of events
- Rating consumer products



Construct Validity of Behavioral Observations

- **Observational research**
- Some claims based on observational data
 - Observing how much people talk

A



B

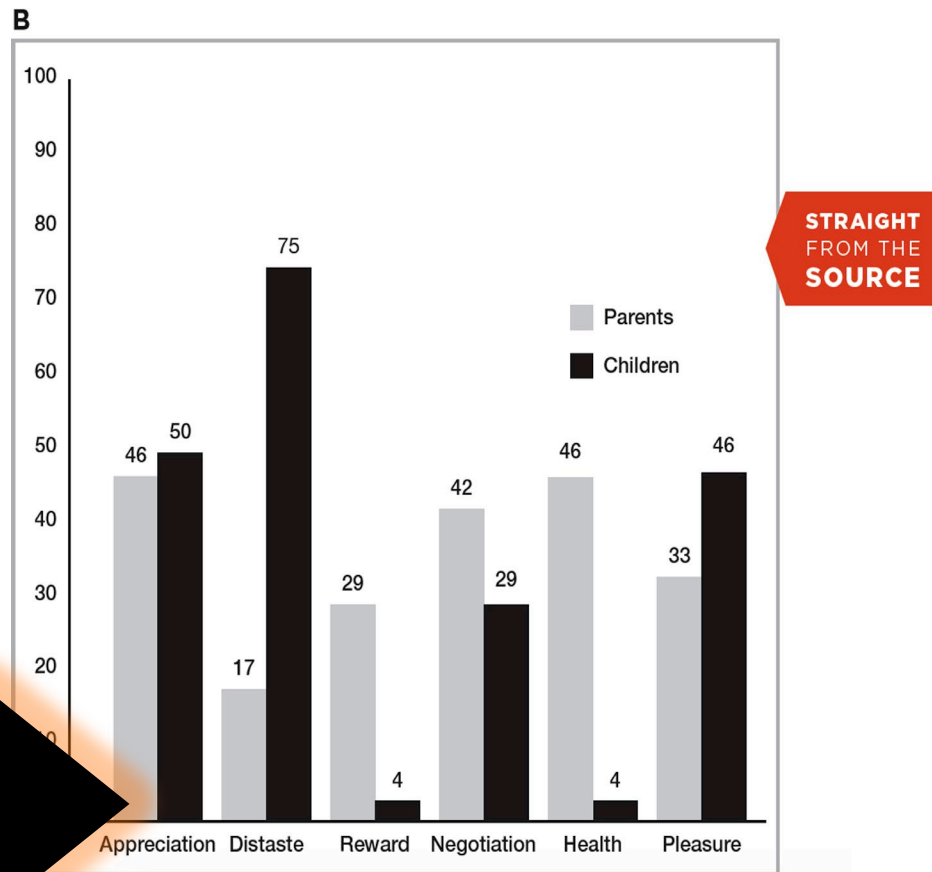
STRAIGHT
FROM THE
SOURCE

Table 1. Estimated number of words spoken per day for female and male study participants across six samples. $N = 396$. Year refers to the year when the data collection started; duration refers to the approximate number of days participants wore the EAR; the weighted average weighs the respective sample group mean by the sample size of the group.

Sample	Year	Location	Duration	Age range (years)	Sample size (N)		Estimated average number (SD) of words spoken per day	
					Women	Men	Women	Men
1	2004	USA	7 days	18–29	56	56	18,443 (7460)	16,576 (7871)
2	2003	USA	4 days	17–23	42	37	14,297 (6441)	14,060 (9065)
3	2003	Mexico	4 days	17–25	31	20	14,704 (6215)	15,022 (7864)
4	2001	USA	2 days	17–22	47	49	16,177 (7520)	16,569 (9108)
5	2001	USA	10 days	18–26	7	4	15,761 (8985)	24,051 (10,211)
6	1998	USA	4 days	17–23	27	20	16,496 (7914)	12,867 (8343)
Weighted average							16,215 (7301)	15,669 (8633)

Some Claims Based on Observational Data

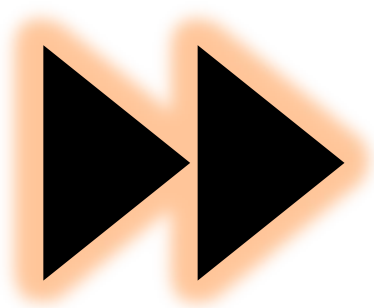
- Observing where babies and caregivers look
- Observing families in the evening
- Observations can be better than self-reports



A

Dinnertime talk. Coders documented whether each family member present engaged in each of the following six types of food-related talk: (a) expressions of appreciation, (b) expressions of distaste, (c) reference to health, (d) reference to pleasure, (e) reference to food as a reward, and (f) negotiation over the terms of food rewards or penalties.

Making Reliable and Valid Observations



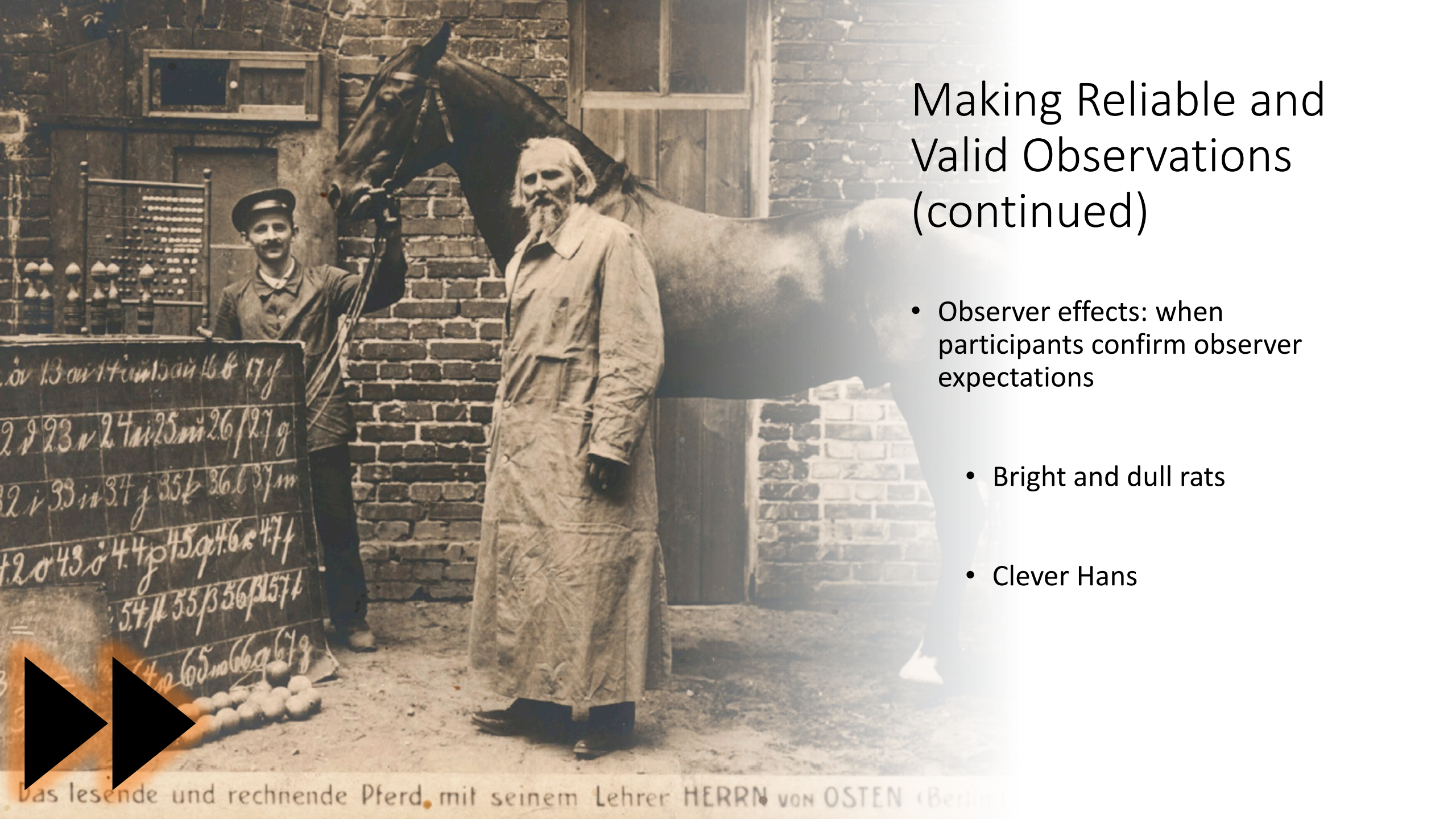
Making reliable and valid observations



Observer bias: when observers see what they expect to see

Making Reliable and Valid Observations (continued)

- Observer effects: when participants confirm observer expectations
- Bright and dull rats
- Clever Hans



Das lesende und rechnende Pferd, mit seinem Lehrer HERRN von OSTEN (Berlin)

Emotional tone. To measure emotional tone, coders rated the extent to which the behavior of each parent was marked by verbal and nonverbal markers of coldness/hostility or warmth/happiness on a Likert scale (1 = *cold/hostile*; 4 = *neutral*; 7 = *warm/happy*). Cold/hostile emotional tone was defined as short communication, flat or angry affect, and no evidence of positive affect. Neutral tone was defined as a task oriented, practical tone that was neither cold/hostile nor warm/happy. Warm/happy emotional tone was defined as warm voice tones, smiles, laughter, and head nods with no evidence of negative affect. Coders independently rated a parent's emotional tone when they appeared in the video (a) alone, (b) with their partner (if present), or (c) with their 7- to 12-year-old child (if present). The latter rating was restricted to the 7- to 12-year-old child that all families were required to have to standardize interaction that might otherwise vary with stage of child development. Thus, up to three emotional tone variables could be rated for each parent in each 30-s video slice. Interrater reliabilities for emotional tone alone (ICC = .92), with partner (ICC = .91), and with child (ICC = .95) were high.

STRAIGHT
FROM THE
SOURCE

Interrater reliability
of this observation.

Preventing Observer Bias and Observer Effects

Masked design



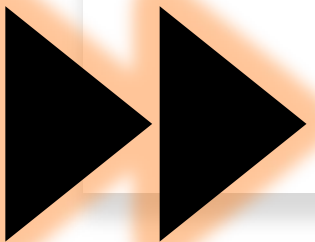
Reactivity: When Participants React to Being Watched

- Solution 1: Blend in
 - **Unobtrusive observations**
- Solution 2: Wait it out
- Solution 3: Measure the behavior's results



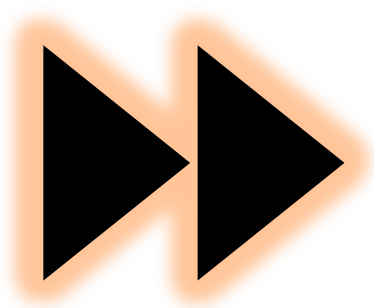
Observing People Ethically

- Is it ethical for researchers to observe the behaviors of others?
 - Short answer: It depends.





Instead...





Subverting Measurement

Subverting Measurement Roadmap

Questions

- Quality
- Ordering

Respondent Bias

- Acquiescence
- Social desirability
- Habituation
- Demand Characteristics

Question Quality:

Leading questions and wording bias

Elaborating on a respondent's answer puts words in their mouth and, while

- leading questions and wording aren't types of bias themselves, they lead to bias or are a result of bias.

Researchers do this because they are trying to confirm a

- hypothesis,
- build rapport or
- overestimate their understanding of the respondent.

To minimize this bias...

- To minimize this bias,
 - ask questions that use the respondents' language and
 - inquire about the implications of a respondent's thoughts and reactions.
- Avoid summarizing what the respondents said in your own words
 - and do not take what they said further.
- Try not to assume relationships between a feeling and a behavior.





Question Quality

- Questions should never be worded in a way that'll sway the reader to one side of the argument.
 - Usually, you can tell a question is leading if it includes non-neutral wording.



Question Quality

- Sometimes questions will be written in a way that
 - forces the respondent into an answer that
 - doesn't accurately reflect
- their opinion or situation.
- leading contributors to respondents abandoning surveys.



Leading Questions

BAD: How short was Napoleon?

Leading Questions

- **BAD:** How short was Napoleon?
 - The word “short” immediately brings images to the mind of the respondent. If the question is rewritten to be neutral-sounding, it can eliminate the leading bias.



Leading Questions

BAD: Should concerned parents use infant car seats?

Examples Leading Questions

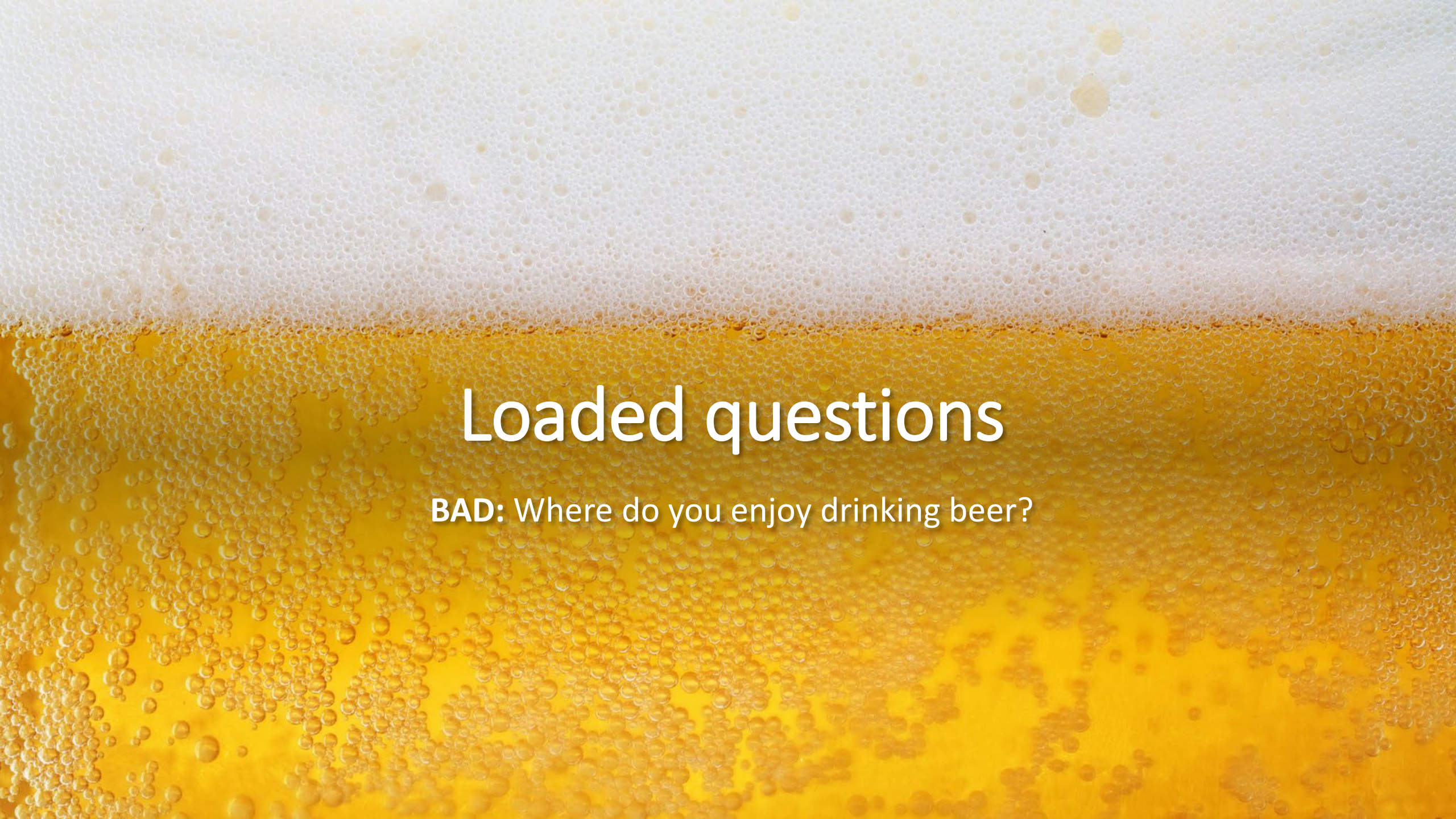
Should concerned parents use infant car seats?

- The term “concerned parents” leads the respondent away from the topic at hand.
- Instead, stay focused by only including what is needed in the question.

Leading Questions

- **BAD:** Should concerned parents use infant car seats?
- **GOOD:** Do you think special car seats should be required for infant passengers?





Loaded questions

BAD: Where do you enjoy drinking beer?

Loaded questions

- **BAD:** Where do you enjoy drinking beer?
- By answering this question,
 - the respondent is announcing that they drink beer.
 - However, many people dislike beer or
 - will not drink alcohol and therefore can't answer the question truthfully.
- Usually, loaded questions are best avoided by pretesting your survey to make sure every respondent has a way to answer honestly.

Question Ordering

One question can influence answers to subsequent questions,

- creating question-order bias.

Respondents are primed by the words and

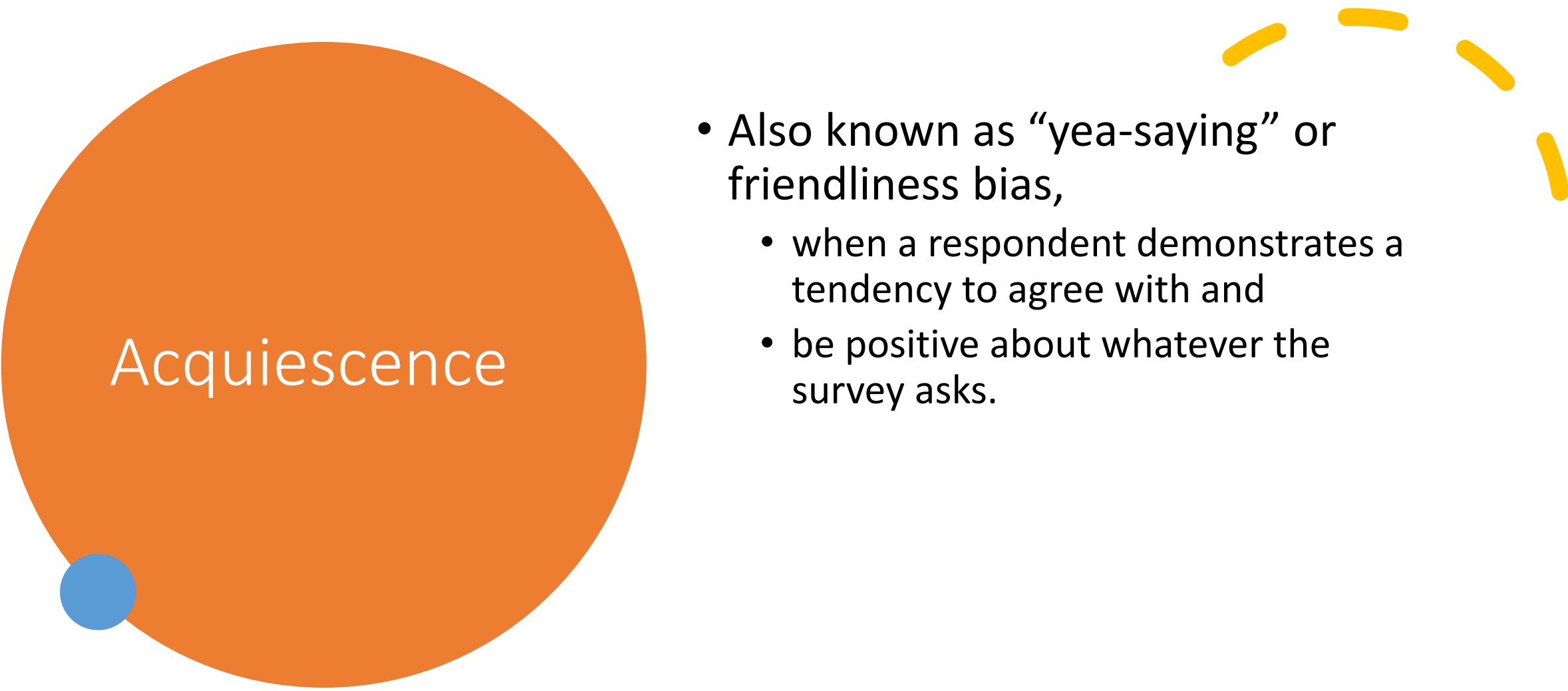
- ideas presented in questions that
- impact their thoughts, feelings and attitudes on subsequent questions.

Question Ordering

- For example, if a respondent rates one product a 10 and is then asked to rate a competitive product,
 - they will make a rating that is relative to the 10 they just provided.
- Although question-order bias is sometimes unavoidable,
 - asking general questions before specific,
 - unaided before aided and positive before negative will minimize bias.



Respondent Bias



Acquiescence

- Also known as “yea-saying” or friendliness bias,
 - when a respondent demonstrates a tendency to agree with and
 - be positive about whatever the survey asks.

Acquiescence



In other words, they think every idea is a good one and

can see themselves liking, buying and acting upon every situation that is proposed.



Some people have acquiescent personalities, while

others acquiesce because they perceive the interviewer to be an expert.

Acquiescence

- Acquiescence is the easy way out, as it takes less effort than carefully weighing each option.
- This path escalates if fatigue sets in –
 - some people will agree just to complete the interview/survey.
- To avoid it, researchers must replace questions that
 - imply there is a right answer with those that
 - focus on the respondent's true point of view.



Social desirability



respondents answering questions in a way that

they think will lead to being accepted and liked.



Regardless of the research format,

some people will report inaccurately on sensitive or personal topics to present themselves in the best possible light.

Social desirability

Minimize this bias by focusing on unconditional positive regard.

This includes phrasing questions to show it's okay to answer in a way that is not socially desirable.

Social desirability



Indirect questioning

asking about what a third-party thinks, feels and how they will behave –
can also be used for socially sensitive questions.



This allows
respondents to
project their own
feelings onto others

and still provide
honest,
representative
answers.

Habitation



Respondents provide the same answers to questions that are worded in similar ways.



being responsive and paying attention takes a lot of energy.

To conserve energy, our brains habituate or go on autopilot.

Habituation

Respondents often show signs of fatigue,

- such as mentioning that the questions seem repetitive, or
- start giving similar responses across multiple questions.

Interviewers must keep the engagement conversational and

- continue to vary question wording to minimize habituation.

Demand Characteristics



When respondents know – or suspect – the sponsor of the research,

their feelings and opinions about that sponsor may bias their answers.



Respondents' views on the sponsoring organization's mission or core beliefs,



for example, can influence how they answer all questions related to that brand.

Demand Characteristics

This is an especially important type of bias for interviewers to navigate by maintaining a neutral stance,

limiting moderator reinforcement to positive respondent feedback that can be

- construed as interview affiliation to brand and reiterating,
- when possible, the interview's independent status.

To Recap

- We learned about:
 - Question Effects Like
 - Quality
 - Ordering
 - Respondent Biases, including
 - Acquiescence
 - Social desirability
 - Habituation
 - Demand Characteristics





Wrapping Up...